

MANY MORE SIDES: DEBATE ACROSS THE CURRICULUM AND AROUND THE GLOBE

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Abstract: Dr. Alfred “Tuna” Snider expanded the boundaries of debate by bringing it to new regions and promoting it in educational contexts outside of the communication discipline. His scholarship has become the resource guide for debate across the curriculum courses and programs around the world. This paper extends his work by providing a rationale for inclusion of debate across the curriculum in English language learner contexts. The implementation of English through debate, which has been effectively employed as a U.S. university course, and in several of Dr. Snider’s debate institutes, including Beihang University and the International Debate Academy Slovenia, is then described in several contexts. Finally, a discussion of the inherent intersection of language, content, critical thinking, and communication in debate will highlight the ways in which debate across the curriculum and in language education supports and expands principles, such as power through education and global citizenship, which were pervasive through Tuna’s life and work, and contribute to his legacy.

I see debate growing and prospering around the world. The time seems right to strike some sparks wherever we can in the hope that it will create additional light. Do your best and trust yourself.

-Alfred Charles Snider “Sparking the Debate”

In his preface to the 2006 edition of *Debate Across the Curriculum*, Dr. Alfred “Tuna” Snider discusses the global search for educational methods that are active, and combine knowledge integration, critical thinking,

and communication skills. His work has become the resource guide for debate across the curriculum courses and programs around the world.

Dr. Snider was involved in academic debate for over fifty years, from his influential roles in the Urban Debate league, World Schools Debate, and multiple university debate associations, to his charge of promoting debate around the world and through the internet.¹ Throughout his career, he consistently worked to increase access to debate with the hope of contributing toward a better future. The title of the international conference he organized, *Thinking and Speaking a Better World: Argumentation, rhetoric, debate, and the pedagogy of empowerment*, begins to capture the essence of his legacy. I was fortunate to work with him on several debate projects, where I had the opportunity to integrate my classroom experience into workshops and trainings for emerging and developing debate networks. Dr. Snider believed that debate in the classroom is a valuable response to limits in education and citizenship, and he worked tirelessly to spread debate around the globe.

This essay commemorates the influence that Dr. Snider had on expanding debate education, through an analysis of debate across the curriculum, and its application beyond traditional content courses. The discussion will center on debate in language learning, which is a natural extension of his work, and supports his emphasis on increased access to debate for everyone. I began utilizing debate for language learning in Italy and the Czech Republic, and through the years I collaborated with Dr. Snider to develop

this pedagogy in China, Slovenia, Qatar and the United States. I will first present a rationale for the inclusion of debate across the curriculum in English language learner contexts, and review the merits of debate as an educational method that meets the goals of language facilitators. The discussion will then turn to the application of English through debate in varied classroom contexts. Finally, a summary of debate's inherent intersection of language, content, critical thought, and communication will highlight the ways in which debate across the curriculum and around the world supports and expands principles, which were pervasive through Tuna's life and work, such as power through education and global citizenship.

Debate across the curriculum

Oral communication is often included as part of the mission statement or goals of general education for undergraduate programs in the United States, yet it is often unclear how this is translated in the curriculum. The Boyer Commission on Educating Undergraduates in the Research University (1998) states that undergraduate education must include strong written and oral communication skills, and that these skills *should* be integrated in content courses. An increased focus on academic oral communication is an important step toward our understanding of students' language needs.

Dr. Snider pushed for more active learning, tasks that encouraged higher-order thinking, and student-centered education. He identified debate as a technique that addressed these shortcomings in educational systems (Snider & Schnurer, 2002; Snider, 2014). Mauranen (2002) pointed to an increased demand for presentation skills in academia, and Bellon (2000) made a research based justification, specifically for

¹ See Snider (2006), for a discussion of the obstacles and solutions to overcoming "the tyranny of distance and time" through internet debating.

debate across the curriculum, synthesizing findings on the general benefits of communication across the curriculum, with research on the benefits of competitive debate, and studies in educational psychology. This work concluded that debate across the curriculum meets the criteria for practices that best facilitate learning, and found a great deal of overlap between lists of teaching reforms and suggestions from the cognitive studies literature and debate intensive instruction. Debate across the curriculum fosters the kind of knowledge construction supported by Newmann and Wehlage (1995) in their framework for instruction that “engages students in using their minds well” (p. 8). Debate across the curriculum also contributes to meaningful learning by asking students to organize information, consider alternatives, and practice extended exchange. Dr. Snider’s scholarship both illustrates the benefits of debate across the curriculum and provides guidance on its implementation, and it has therefore expanded the reach of debate in education. There is powerful support for the benefits to both students and teachers that participate in debate across the curriculum programs, and English through debate extends these benefits to language learners.

Debate in language learning contexts

There is an increasing awareness among language educators of the need to integrate meaningful language use across the curriculum. Learners, often preparing for or immersed in disciplinary courses, face a variety of communication demands. Debate and critical thinking can play an important role in the language classroom, where instructors are working to help prepare students for their future language needs. Clennel (1999) cited oral presentation as useful English for academic purposes activity, and an increase in spoken language tasks has long been promoted in English as a Foreign

Language curricula (Carter, Goold, & Madeley, 1993). While there are clear benefits to traditional oral communication tasks in language teaching, there is an even stronger rationale to including debate activities in these classrooms. Debate emphasizes skill integration, and critical thinking is developed throughout the process. Some of the most noteworthy advantages to using debate in language learning classrooms include an increase in critical thinking, language skill integration, communicative competence, enhanced learning, and productive assessment.

Debate promotes a variety of critical thinking skills, and this is supported across studies. Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt, & Loudon (1999) conducted a meta-analysis of the impact of forensics and communication education. They found that all oral communication instruction had a positive impact on critical thinking, and that competitive speech and debate showed the largest gains. While preparing for debate, students are asked to develop a perspective, explore beliefs and theories, analyze arguments, evaluate the credibility or bias of a source, and distinguish between relevant and irrelevant information. Students are encouraged to question deeply, develop and assess solutions to problems, compare and contrast, make inferences, recognize contradictions, and explore implications and consequences. Debate helps teach students to conduct research and develop backing for their arguments. As students bring several sources of information together, they must synthesize their findings into cohesive arguments with logical support. In addition, new information will need to be integrated with existing knowledge, so that learners can make sense out of what they find in order to develop clear and consistent arguments. This kind of activation of prior knowledge leads to deeper processing, and is enhanced by

analyzing contrasting cases or positions (Schwartz and Bransford, 1998; Barron et al., 1998). Debate offers an ideal exercise in this type of knowledge development and differentiation. The insights gained throughout the process allow students to expand, activate, and construct knowledge, and these skills can be transferred to new materials and contexts.

In addition to critical thinking, debate reinforces all four language skills. During debate preparation, students will develop strong reading, writing, and note-taking skills. Learners must skim and scan a wide variety of sources during their search for information and read key materials in depth in order to prepare for debates. Writing practice is highlighted as students take notes, and complete argumentative essays can be assigned during the preparation phase. Participants then practice careful listening during debates because taking notes enables them to respond to the speeches of others. There is naturally a strong focus on speaking, and language is the key to delivering a clear, coherent speech. Individual presentations can be used as building blocks for debates and contribute to this integrated skills practice.

Oral presentations have become increasingly required in university classrooms, and students benefit from the practice of demonstrating knowledge and participating in this type of exchange. Debate activities push students to develop their public speaking skills, help prepare them for academic work, and boost their confidence and language learning. In addition to language skill development, debate tasks advance intercultural communicative competence by combining cultural awareness and linguistic fluency (Vigier & Le Floch, 2011), a common objective in language programs.

Debate provides opportunities for improved learning. Students take on an invested role in their own development, which helps to increase motivation and interest, and creates more responsible learners. Debate reinforces collaboration and cooperation by having students work in pairs or teams to share ideas, resulting in a dynamic learning environment. Research in Concept-Oriented Reading Instruction has shown that social collaboration increases learning through the sharing of ideas and background knowledge (Swan, 2003), and the empirical link between interaction and second language acquisition points to improved learning through interactive tasks (Keck, Iberri-Shea, Tracy, & Wa-Mbaleka, 2006). The opportunities in debate offer the best of both worlds, making students capable of responsible motivated learning and able to reap the benefits of focused interaction.

Debate is a method of performance assessment, which taps many of the instructional goals of the language classroom. Students are provided the opportunity to demonstrate what they have learned rather than focusing on their shortcomings. This form of assessment pushes students to synthesize knowledge from a variety of sources and take on a teaching role; they choose the focus and explain their position to the rest of the class. This type of self-explanation has been found to correspond with higher levels of comprehension and conceptual understanding (Chi, DeLeeuw, Chiu, & LaVancher, 1994). Simply put, students learn more through having to explain information to others. Additionally, planning for debates and preparing for questions from their peers leads to deeper processing and a more complete understanding of the content. There is also support showing that tasks involving planning lead to more complex and fluent use of language (Wesche and Skehan 2002). The

preparation and execution of debates allow for cyclical planning, revision, and demonstration.

These advantages make a strong case for debate in the language learning curriculum. English through debate integrates content, language, and strategy objectives, and students develop an increased motivation and engagement with the content. Language skills will improve because students are using language for specific purposes and working toward personal goals. Students will develop critical thinking through expanding, integrating, and constructing knowledge. Debate empowers students as they make decisions about their learning and display their knowledge in meaningful ways. These benefits provide a clear justification for expanding debate across the curriculum and to language learners around the globe. Dr. Snider promoted the use of debate in a variety of educational contexts and believed that it developed a skill-set that students need in the twenty-first century. His work provided guidance on using debate across subject areas, and *Many Sides: Debate across the curriculum* has now been published in several languages. Utilizing debate in the language classroom is an extension of his work to expand debate and improve education.

Implementation of English through debate

I developed the English through debate curriculum after witnessing the many benefits debate brought to my forensics students. I had just completed my degree in Teaching English as a Second Language, and I was simultaneously coaching an intercollegiate debate team and teaching in the intensive English program. I strongly agreed with Dr. Snider's philosophies of increasing access to debate and utilizing debate as an educational method across the curriculum, and I sought to further this work by integrating debate into my

language classrooms. This extension of debate expands Dr. Snider's charge of spreading debate around the globe, as many of the students were on exchange and would return to regions that did not yet have developed debate programs. I would later bring the course to regions that were developing debate, but where students felt their language proficiencies limited access. Dr. Snider's support was invaluable as he engaged in discussions on the curriculum and offered feedback based on his experiences. He served as a respondent when I presented the curriculum at the *Thinking and Speaking a Better World: Argumentation, rhetoric, debate, and the pedagogy of empowerment* conference in Qatar, and included workshop sessions in his academy curriculum. Versions of this program have been field tested in academies in China, Slovenia, Italy, and the Czech Republic, and in university courses at Northern Arizona University and the United States Air Force Academy. I have seen firsthand the benefits of debate and debate across the curriculum, and English through debate increases access to these benefits. English through debate has been realized as a semester long course, a condensed summer session, and a workshop. In each case, debate is the vehicle by which students develop skills and master content.

English through debate has been utilized in a wide range of academic contexts, and the program has been developed over the past ten years. The first implementation of the course was at the United World College of the Adriatic in Duino, Italy. The students were primarily secondary school teachers from Bulgaria and Haiti with little to no debate experience. This was a three-week intensive course, where we were able to build skills culminating in a research based debate. The teachers were initially resistant and expressed a desire for more traditional instruction, such as explicit

grammar and pronunciation exercises. In order to increase motivation, I needed to spend more time than I had initially anticipated discussing theory and collaborating on course and learner objectives. For these seasoned instructors, a walk-through of the syllabus with explanations of the theoretical decisions activities were built on was critical to buy-in. Once we worked through this initial hesitancy, and they were invested in the curriculum, their competencies flourished. Although I did not conduct a controlled pre-test, gains in speaking confidence and fluency were marked by their ability to deliver longer and more complex speeches. Later that summer, I taught a similar course for high school students in the Czech Republic. These students were eager to use debate for language development, and described the method as motivating. They were excited to be doing something “different” and enjoyed the competitive aspect of debate. Although this group was significantly less interested in acquisition and instruction theories, the objectives of the course were made explicit and learner goals helped inform the curriculum. This direct discussion of course objectives and adaptation to each specific context has become a core element of the program.

At Northern Arizona University, English through debate took the form of a semester long course within a program in intensive English. This course was particularly interesting, in that the demographics of the class were evenly split between students from China and Saudi Arabia. There was a stark contrast in the written and verbal proficiencies of the two groups, with the Saudi students demonstrating significantly more comfort with oral communication and bringing experience with spoken English outside of academic contexts. The Chinese students had limited authentic oral communication experience, but near perfect

written grammar. The program provided a unique opportunity for students to both play to their strengths and push themselves to fill gaps. By requiring tasks that relied heavily on discreet skills first, and then applying them in coordination, the curriculum allowed for enhanced skill development and integration. Students took on the roles of both teacher and student within their debate partnerships, as partnerships between Saudi and Chinese student brought differing strengths and varied experience. In pairs, students negotiated meaning, corrected and explained errors, and demonstrated improved oral and written forms during preparation for the debates. Partners did not share a common first language, which removed the tendency to use anything but English during research, reading, note-taking, or discussion. This negotiation of both the meaning of research, and its application to their positions and presentations, pushed them to advance their language and communicative competencies.

At the United States Air Force Academy, English through debate was realized as an instructional unit and culminating activity. This was a single support course within a core English medium curriculum. These exchange students had been selected as military and academic representatives of their respective countries. They were exceptional, and their language ability was advanced, with the predominant goal being higher level fluency and communicative competence. English through debate was a perfect fit for this context because the competitive nature of debate was highly motivating for these students. Fluency and communicative competence was explicitly demonstrated and contributed to “winning.” This competitive aspect pushed their output and contributed to measurable gains.

The third context where English through debate was

introduced involved debate academies in Slovenia and Beijing. These were the only debate specific settings, and the students readily adopted the method, which has been implemented several times, both as a workshop and as a teacher-training seminar. Students familiar with debate already know the impact it can have on language development. Making explicit connections while combining language and debate instruction has allowed students to access debate with more confidence, integrate language skills more effectively, and improve fluency. The enthusiasm and motivation of these students has helped to drive further innovations in the course.

Core Requirements

English through debate is not a singular realization independent of context.² The objectives and backgrounds of the students inform each program. The approach, however, is unified, through two core requirements:

The program uses authentic texts, authentic interaction, and meaningful content. Students should engage with and sort through several sources of information for optimal language and critical thinking development. Although there is a great deal of planning in the debates, they cannot be entirely scripted. There must be genuine interaction between participants. The content of the debates is meaningful, either through its relevance to the course or because students have input on the topics. This provides for increased motivation and deeper processing.

The program combines language, content, and learning objectives, and is adapted to the needs of

² See Iberri-Shea (2009), for a guide to implementing public speaking and debate tasks in English language teaching.

a particular group of students. The focus may vary based on context, but the goals for each element are clear and the instructor considers student needs when planning the trajectory of the course.

Considerations

These requirements allow for a maximum amount of adaptation. English through debate can range from a language focus to a knowledge construction or skill focus. As the course has evolved, I have identified some additional points of consideration:

Consider the language background and language learning experiences of your students, and make your outcomes explicit. This is merely an expansion of the core requirement of adaptation to the needs of students. Early on, when I introduced some teachers to this program, there was initial resistance to the approach. Depending on the student's previous language education, English through debate may violate expectations, especially of grammar-based or rote learning. Providing a more thorough academic justification, a more directed explanation of outcomes, and a slower integration of debate activities may be beneficial. For beginners, topic difficulty must be adapted and some explicit language instruction is a prerequisite.

Start with problems and move to projects.

Although debate tasks can be integrated into any class session, a problem to project approach best captures the benefits of English through debate. Beginning with an introduction to contrasting positions, research skills, public speaking practice, and argument development, will go a long way toward building critical thinking and language skills. A formal debate works best as a culminating activity that students have prepared for.

Conclusion

When utilizing classroom debate, there is an inherent intersection between language, content, critical thought, and communication, and this fundamental component of the activity makes it an ideal exercise across the curriculum. There is plentiful evidence that debate has a significant impact on critical thinking skills—a paramount goal in academia (Allen et al., 1999)—and the integration across the curriculum has been justified through the research (Bellon, 2000). Debate has the potential to benefit students in all disciplines, and this benefit must go beyond the traditional content classrooms. I concur with Dr. Snider, that debate should exist throughout education and society, because debate has the potential to bring out the best in students and citizens alike. Debate opens up the world, and the possibilities for global good are limitless. Tuna believed in empowerment through education and global citizenship, so it follows that debate should never be isolated to elite students or privileged regions.

Along with case studies and predictive research, there are numerous anecdotes of language mastery through debate. The next step is additional empirical study of the effects of debate on language learning. I encourage all educators to utilize debate in the classroom as an effective means of integrating critical thinking, language, communicative competence, and improved learning. The benefits of debate are boundless. Let us extend these gains across the curriculum and around the globe, so that we all can be thinking and speaking a better world.

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